

POSC 459: Social Welfare Politics and Policy

Fall 2026

Faculty Information

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Office Hours: Mondays, 3:00–4:00 p.m. and 5:30–6:30 p.m.; Tuesdays, 12:00–1:00 p.m.; and by [appointment](#).

Schedule meetings: dadams.io/appointments

Course Communication

All course announcements and communications will be sent via *Canvas* and university email. Students are responsible for regularly checking their *Canvas* notifications and email, and for ensuring that Canvas notifications are set to receive course messages. Students are expected to check *Canvas* and their email at least once daily.

Response time: I will strive to respond to all student emails and *Canvas* messages within 24 hours, except on weekends and holidays. If you have not received a response within 24 hours, please send a follow-up message. If you are still waiting after 48 hours, contact me via phone or SMS at (657) 278-4770.

Technical Problems

If you encounter any technical difficulties, contact the instructor immediately to document the problem. Then contact: [student IT help desk](#), [email](#), phone (657) 278-8888, walk-in

[student genius center](#), or online chat via the [portal](#) (“Online IT Help” then “Live Chat”).

For issues with Canvas: Canvas Support Hotline = (657) 278-8888, [search the CSUF Canvas Guides](#), or [report a problem](#).

Alternative submission: If you cannot submit an assignment via *Canvas*, contact the professor as soon as possible to document the issue and arrange an alternative.

Course Information

Prefix, number, title: POSC 459, *Social Welfare Politics and Policy*

Meeting times: In-Person, Monday & Wednesday, 1:00–2:15 p.m., GH 305

Units: 3 **Schedule Code:** 17538 **Section:** 01

Course requisite(s): POSC 100 or graduate standing

Catalog description: American social policies—welfare, Social Security, health care—and the political environment in which they exist. Origins, implementation, and reforms of current social policies, emphasizing questions of effectiveness and policy improvement.

Policy regarding the use of generative AI: See the *Policy on the Use of Generative AI and Other Technology* section below.

Course materials and equipment: Canvas; access to course readings; laptop recommended

Required texts: Howard (2007); Campbell (2014); Desmond (2023); plus ebook readings through Pollak Library (see *Required Texts* below)

Course Description

This course is an intensive introduction to U.S. social welfare policy and politics. It has four parts: the big picture (who are the poor, and how did the welfare state develop?); the programs (social insurance, the safety net, tax expenditures); two case studies in major reform (welfare reform and the ACA); and the political forces that shape all of it (public opinion, interest groups, race, and gender).

The course moves between levels of analysis. Comparative welfare state theory sits alongside individual family narratives; legislative history sits alongside street-level program design. Both matter. You cannot understand why TANF looks the way it does without understanding the politics that produced it, and you cannot evaluate whether the ACA succeeded

without understanding what it was actually trying to accomplish.

This course is taught from a political science and policy analysis perspective. Political science helps explain *why* we get the policies we get; policy analysis helps evaluate *whether those policies do what they claim*. Both lenses are at work throughout the semester.

Student Learning Outcomes

By the end of the semester, students will be able to:

1. Describe the core architecture of the U.S. welfare state: social insurance, public assistance, tax expenditures, and public-private arrangements.
2. Trace the political development of major programs (Social Security, TANF, Medicaid, ACA) and connect that history to current policy debates.
3. Apply key concepts from political science and policy analysis to evaluate welfare programs: policy feedback, institutional design, interest group politics, and public opinion.
4. Analyze how race and gender have structured both program design and access to benefits.
5. Situate U.S. welfare policy within a comparative frame and explain the sources of American exceptionalism.
6. Construct an evidence-based policy argument using primary sources and scholarly literature.

Required Texts

The following are available for purchase at the Titan bookstore:

1. Howard, Christopher. 2007. *The Welfare State Nobody Knows: Debunking Myths About U.S. Social Policy*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
2. Campbell, Andrea Louise. 2014. *Trapped in America's Safety Net: One Family's Struggle*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
3. Desmond, Matthew. 2023. *Poverty, by America*. New York, NY: Crown.

Required Texts Available as Ebooks at Pollak Library

1. Rank, Mark Robert, Lawrence M. Eppard, and Heather E. Bullock. 2021. *Poorly Understood: What America Gets Wrong About Poverty*. Oxford University Press.
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=6461413>
2. Howard, Christopher. 2023. *Who Cares: The Social Safety Net in America*. Oxford University Press.
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?pq-origsite=primo&docID=7099798>
3. Jacobs, Lawrence and Theda Skocpol. 2016. *Health Care Reform and American Politics: What Everyone Needs to Know*, 3rd ed. Oxford University Press.
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=4310736>
4. Béland, Daniel, Kimberly J. Morgan, and Christopher Howard, eds. 2015. *The Oxford Handbook of U.S. Social Policy*. Oxford University Press.
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=1825907>
5. Mettler, Suzanne. 1998. *Dividing Citizens: Gender and Federalism in New Deal Public Policy*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.
<https://www-jstor-org.lib-proxy.fullerton.edu/stable/10.7591/j.ctv5rdzmfh>
A 2018 edition exists. The copy licensed to us is the 1998 original, and the assigned chapter numbers refer to it, so read the JSTOR copy above rather than hunting for the newer one. (*Week 13.*)

Additional Readings

Additional readings—articles, book chapters, policy documents, and documentary viewing guides—are posted on Canvas and noted in the course schedule. Canvas readings are required and carry equal weight to book readings.

Student Resources Website

It is the student's responsibility to read and understand the required and important [student information for course syllabi](#). Included is information about:

- University learning goals and General Education learning objectives

- Students' rights to accommodations
- Campus student support resources and academic integrity
- Emergency preparedness; library and IT services
- Software privacy, accessibility statement, diversity statement, and land acknowledgement
- Final exam schedule and semester calendar

Course Requirements

Course Format

This is an in-person lecture and discussion course meeting twice weekly for 75 minutes. Students complete assigned readings before class; class time is divided between lecture, structured discussion, and periodic documentary screenings. Three weeks are structured as asynchronous work weeks with no in-person meetings (see below).

Three Asynchronous Weeks

Three weeks are designated asynchronous. There are no in-person meetings those weeks. In Weeks 4 and 9, students complete the assigned readings, watch the designated documentary, and submit that week's discussion paper by Friday at 11:59 p.m. Week 14 carries no new deliverable: it is reading and independent work time, with term papers and graduate outlines due that Wednesday. Specific instructions will be posted to Canvas in advance.

- **Week 4 (Async):** Political development of the welfare state; *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 2
- **Week 9 (Async):** Welfare reform; *Two American Families*
- **Week 14 (Async):** Public opinion and interest groups; term papers and grad outlines due. No documentary and no discussion paper—the week is reading and independent work

Graded Work

- **Required for all students (60% total):** Attendance and Participation (10%); Discussion Papers, five across the term (10%); Midterm Exam (20%); Final Exam (20%).
- **Undergraduates only (40% total):**
 - **Policy Brief (20% across three stages):** Program selection (credit/no credit, due Monday September 21); a source and claims memo (5%, due Friday October 9); and the brief itself (15%, due Wednesday October 28). A 3–4 page analysis of one program: OASDI, SSI, TANF, Unemployment Insurance, Medicaid, Medicare, SNAP, or the EITC. Cover the program's stated purpose, who it serves, its major design features, and one significant reform debate. Academic writing conventions and source citations required.
 - **Term Paper (20%):** A 6–8 page research paper building on the policy brief. Analyze the political and policy-relevant strengths and weaknesses of your program and develop a reform proposal, drawing on course concepts and the program's political history.
- **Graduate students only (40% total):**
 - **Research Proposal (10%):** Topic, research question, and preliminary bibliography.
 - **Introduction/Outline/Annotated Bibliography (10%):** Substantial revision from the proposal with clear research design and sources.
 - **Final Research Paper (20%):** A 10–15 page original research paper due Monday, December 14, at the start of the final exam.

Graduate Student Requirements

Graduate students complete all readings including graduate-only readings posted on Canvas. They take both the midterm and final exams and write five discussion papers. In place of the undergraduate policy brief and term paper, graduate students complete a scaffolded 10–15 page original research paper sequence with staged feedback and revision across three milestones:

1. **Research Proposal (10%)** (1–2 pages): Due Week 7, October 5.

- Identify policy topic, core research question, and why the question matters for welfare politics/policy.
- Include a working thesis or argument direction.
- Include a preliminary bibliography (minimum 6 credible sources, including scholarly sources).
- Instructor feedback will focus on scope, feasibility, and argument focus.

2. Introduction, Outline, and Annotated Bibliography (10%): Due Week 14, December 2.

- Revised introduction with clear thesis and paper roadmap.
- Detailed section outline showing claim flow and supporting evidence for each section.
- Annotated bibliography with brief annotations describing each source's argument and relevance to your project.
- Substantial revision from the proposal is expected; this milestone should show a sharpened question and stronger evidence base.

3. Final Research Paper (20%) (10–15 pages): Due Monday, December 14, at the start of the final exam.

- Original analysis that synthesizes course concepts, scholarly literature, and policy evidence.
- Clear argument structure (thesis, evidence, analysis, counterargument/limitations, conclusion).
- Proper citation and academic writing conventions.
- The final submission should directly incorporate and respond to feedback from Milestones 1 and 2.

Grading Policies and Standards

a. Grading scale: See Table 1 for the full letter-grade percentage scale used in this course.

b. Required course assignments (undergraduate): See Table 2 for undergraduate assignment weights and due dates.

Table 1: Grade scale

Grade	Percent	Grade	Percent
A+	97.0–100.0	C+	77.0–79.9
A	94.0–96.9	C	74.0–76.9
A-	90.0–93.9	C-	70.0–73.9
B+	87.0–89.9	D+	67.0–69.9
B	84.0–86.9	D	64.0–66.9
B-	80.0–83.9	D-	61.0–63.9
		F	0.0–60.9

Table 2: Undergraduate assignment weighting

Assignment	Weight	Due
Attendance and Participation	10%	Ongoing
Discussion Papers (5 x 2%)	10%	Fridays 9/18, 10/2, 10/23, 11/6, 11/20
Midterm Exam	20%	Wednesday, October 14
Policy Brief: Source and Claims Memo (<i>PapyrusAI module</i>)	5%	Friday, October 9
Policy Brief (<i>PapyrusAI module</i>)	15%	Wednesday, October 28
Term Paper (<i>PapyrusAI module</i>)	20%	Wednesday, December 2
Final Exam	20%	Monday, December 14
Total	100%	

Assignments marked (*PapyrusAI module*) have a module built for them specifically, rather than a general-purpose tool pointed at them: the Source and Claims Memo and the Policy Brief share the *Policy Brief Scaffold*, and the term paper has the *Term Paper Dialectical Partner*. The reading journal inside participation has one too, the *Idea Catcher*. These are the AI-integrated pieces of the course design, built to ask questions rather than produce prose. **Using them is optional and no part of your grade depends on it**—see the AI policy section below.

See Table 3 for graduate assignment weights and due dates.

For graduate students, the module built for the track is the *Research Paper Coach*, which opens once your research proposal is in and accompanies the final paper. It argues against your thesis rather than helping you state it. The *Idea Catcher* covers the reading journal here as well. Both are optional on the same terms.

Table 3: Graduate assignment weighting

Assignment	Weight	Due
Attendance and Participation	10%	Ongoing
Discussion Papers (5 x 2%)	10%	Fridays 9/18, 10/2, 10/23, 11/6, 11/20
Midterm Exam	20%	Wednesday, October 14
Research Proposal	10%	Monday, October 5
Introduction, Outline, and Annotated Bibliography	10%	Wednesday, December 2
Final Research Paper (<i>PapyrusAI module</i>)	20%	Monday, December 14
Final Exam	20%	Monday, December 14
Total	100%	

c. Attendance and participation policy: Students are expected to attend all in-person sessions. If you are unable to attend, notify the professor in advance. You are responsible for obtaining any materials or information covered during absences. Participation in in-class activities cannot be made up.

Reading journal. Part of your participation grade is a running reading journal: **ten entries** across the semester logging connections, surprises, and reform-relevant observations from the readings. I check it twice, on **October 14** and **December 9**. **What counts is the entry, not where you wrote it.** *This assignment has a PapyrusAI module, the Idea Catcher*, built for exactly this and nothing else: it takes an entry in under three minutes, never grades it, and does the counting for you. It is the easiest place to keep the journal and I recommend it. A text file, a notebook, or a Canvas page all count the same.

d. Examination dates:

- Midterm Exam: Wednesday, October 14 (in-class)
- Final Exam: **Monday, December 14, 1:00–2:50 p.m.**, GH 305

Format. Both exams are written in class, by hand, in a blue book. **Bring one.** They are not the same kind of exam.

The midterm is course-concept heavy. It draws on the architecture of the American welfare state, the political development of its programs, policy feedback, institutional design, and the arguments we will have had about who the poor are and how we decided to help them—from the assigned readings and from class. It closes with one question about your

own program or research topic, which by then you will have chosen and begun working in the sources.

The final inverts that. It asks you to write at length about *your own* program or topic—what it does, whom it reaches, how it was built, what the argument over it is, and what you would change—applying the concepts and evidence of the course throughout. If you have done your own thinking all semester, you are already prepared for it.

e. Make-up and late submission policy: All assignments are due on the date specified in the course schedule. Extensions must be requested in writing before the due date and will be granted only for illness or other documented unforeseen circumstances. Late work without an approved extension loses one-third of a letter grade per calendar day.

Alternative procedures for submitting work: Students are expected to submit all written work via *Canvas*. Exams are taken in person. If you cannot submit via *Canvas*, contact the professor immediately to arrange an alternative.

f. Authentication of student work: Students may be required to submit their work to a plagiarism detection service. Cal State Fullerton uses Turnitin©. Students should be aware that submitted work may be checked for authenticity and originality.

g. Extra credit: There are no extra credit assignments in this course.

h. Retention of student work: Work submitted for a grade, whether as a hard copy or through Canvas, shall be retained for a reasonable time after the semester ends, not to exceed the last day of the subsequent semester. Students have the right to review graded work in the presence of the instructor. (UPS 320.005)

Academic Integrity

Students are expected to adhere to the highest standards of academic integrity. Any student found to have engaged in academic dishonesty will be subject to the sanctions described in the [Academic Dishonesty Policy](#) (UPS 300.021). Academic dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, cheating, plagiarism, fabrication, facilitating academic dishonesty, and submitting previously graded work without prior authorization. Students are expected to be familiar with the university's policy and to adhere to it in all aspects of this course.

Policy on the Use of Generative AI and Other Technology

Generative AI is permitted in this course, but use must be transparent, intentional, and in service of learning. The core principle is simple: **you must do the intellectual work of this course**. AI can amplify your thinking, but not replace it.

Short version: if a tool suggests new words and you use them, that counts as AI use under this policy.

The test. Most tools now flag problems *and* offer to fix them, so what matters is what the tool hands you. If it only flags a possible problem, that is basic mechanics—spellcheck, punctuation, dictionary and thesaurus lookup, grammar flags—which is always fine and never needs disclosure. If it proposes new wording, a summary, or a rewritten version for you to adopt, this policy covers it. **AI may identify problems in your writing. It may not supply the prose that fixes them.**

This includes AI built into tools you already use, whether or not you switched it on: Smart Compose and “Help me write,” Word Copilot, Apple Intelligence, AI search summaries, and the rewriting half of Grammarly. What counts is what you adopt. You do not have to feel like you “used AI” for it to count. If you are unsure whether something counts, **ask before you submit**—a good-faith question asked in advance is treated as exactly that, and it does not put you under suspicion.

Assignment labels

Every assignment carries one of three labels, stated on the assignment itself. You should never have to infer it.

- **GREEN** — AI permitted within the limits below. No disclosure needed.
- **YELLOW** — Permitted within stated limits. **Disclosure required.**
- **RED** — No AI. The assignment is designed to be completed without it, and doing so is the point.

Red assignments in this course: the Week 2 baseline writing diagnostic, all in-class writing, the midterm exam, and the final exam. Everything else is Green or Yellow; the Canvas policy page lists every assignment by label. **If an assignment has no label**, treat it as Yellow and ask me. An unlabeled assignment is my oversight, not an opening.

Red assignments are not punishments or trust tests. Some capacities only develop when you build them yourself, and I need to see your unaided thinking at least once to be useful to you for the rest of the term.

Permitted and not permitted

Permitted: brainstorming, and working out an outline before you have written the piece; explaining concepts you don't understand, then explaining them back in your own words; locating sources, which you then read yourself; diagnosing problems in your clarity, grammar, or organization; sanity-checking your analysis or logic; generating synthetic examples or test cases for your ideas.

Not permitted: using AI to generate your analysis, arguments, or conclusions; submitting AI-generated text as your own writing; using AI to avoid engaging with course concepts or readings; letting AI do the intellectual heavy lifting—interpreting sources, building arguments, synthesizing ideas. Uploading an assigned reading for a tool to summarize or explain is not permitted unless I explicitly allow it.

Disclosure

On Yellow work, add one or two sentences at the end of the assignment: what tool, and what you used it for. **You do not need to attach prompts, transcripts, or logs unless an assignment specifically asks for them**, and if one does, it will say so. Disclosure is a description of your process, the same way a methods section describes how a study was run. It is not a confession. Disclosing use has never lowered a grade in my courses and it is not going to start. What creates a problem is undisclosed use that shows up in the work. And it does show up.

When the policy is broken

Consequences, proportionate to what happened: a conversation and a revision requirement; a grade penalty; or, for serious or repeated violations, a formal referral under CSUF's Academic Dishonesty Policy (UPS 300.021), which can carry sanctions up to dismissal. Forgetting a disclosure sentence on otherwise honest work is an omission. Passing off generated analysis as your own is deception. They land in very different places.

On detection. I am not going to pretend I can catch everything with software, and **I will not run your writing through an AI detector and treat the output as evidence**. Those tools

are unreliable, and their errors are not evenly distributed. They flag multilingual writers and plain prose at higher rates. What I will do is read carefully, ask you to explain your process, and make judgments based on the work, the assignment rules, and that conversation. *Walk me through how you got here.* If you did the thinking, that is an easy conversation and often a good one.

The full policy is on Canvas

This section is the summary. The full policy—what counts as AI inside ordinary software, the complete assignment-label table, where editing ends and rewriting begins, PapyrusAI setup, why the policy exists, and how AI use is assessed—is the Canvas page “**Policy on the Use of Generative AI and Other Technology.**” That page is authoritative and I keep it current. **Read it before the first Yellow assignment.** If the two ever disagree, tell me, and use the Canvas page until I fix this one.

PapyrusAI is the course-supported AI environment, reached from the left-hand navigation menu in our Canvas site; there is no separate login. Four modules were built for specific assignments in this course—*Idea Catcher* for the reading journal, *Policy Brief Scaffold* for the brief and its memo, *Term Paper Dialectical Partner*, and *Research Paper Coach* for the graduate track—and those assignments are marked in the weighting tables above. They coach rather than draft. A *General Use* module is open for any other work in the course and answers you directly, under the same rules that govern every other tool. Working inside a module also handles your disclosure: the session log can be attached in place of the sentence. Setup instructions are on the Canvas page. Use is encouraged but never required. **You can complete this entire course without PapyrusAI**, at no cost to your grade or standing, and you can switch paths at any point in the semester without redoing work.

Two things about this policy that are not fine print. It **supports Outcomes 3, 4, and 6**, which ask you to evaluate programs, analyze how race and gender structured them, and build arguments from primary sources—judgments you have to make yourself. And it is a **working document, not a settled one**. We will revisit it during the term and work through edge cases that have actually come up. This is a course about how rules get made, whom they burden, and whether they accomplish what they claim, and that includes this rule. If you think it is poorly designed or imposes burden it does not justify, say so, in class or to me directly. I would rather hear it in week three than read it in evaluations.

Technical Competencies

Students need:

- Proficiency with Canvas, including submitting assignments and accessing course materials
- Ability to use university email and Canvas messages for course communication
- Basic word processing skills and ability to export documents to PDF

Calendar of Topics / Schedule of Classes

We will follow the schedule below as closely as possible. If adjustments are needed, you will receive advance notice in class and on *Canvas*.

Key: (Pollak) = Pollak Library eBook **Reading structure:** Core Readings are required. Recommended Readings are optional but encouraged. Grad Extension Readings are required for graduate students.

Important dates:

- Midterm Exam: Wednesday, October 14 (in-class)
- Graduate Research Proposals due: Monday, October 5
- Policy Briefs due (undergraduates): Wednesday, October 28
- Term Papers / Graduate Outlines due: Wednesday, December 2
- Final Exam: **Monday, December 14, 1:00–2:50 p.m.**, GH 305
- Thanksgiving Break: November 23–27 (no class)
- Async Weeks: Week 4 (Sep 14–16), Week 9 (Oct 19–21), Week 14 (Nov 30–Dec 2)

PART I: The Big Picture

8/24 – Week 1: Introduction — What Is the American Welfare State?

Readings

- Rank et al., *Poorly Understood*, Section I: “Who Are the Poor?” pp. 15–49. Available as a Pollak Library ebook—no purchase needed, and the link is under *Required Texts* above.

Film (assigned for viewing on your own; it is part of Discussion Paper 1, due Friday 9/18)

- *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 1 (PBS Frontline, 2020, 54 min.)
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/growing-up-poor-in-america/>

Term paper / research paper introduction

- Overview of the semester writing arc: undergraduates produce a policy brief (Week 10) building into a term paper (Week 14); graduate students produce a research proposal (Week 7), outline (Week 14), and final paper (finals week). Begin collecting reform-relevant observations from this week onward—race, gender, public opinion, and political-feedback themes recur throughout the course and matter for the paper.

PapyrusAI module

- **Idea Catcher** (open from Week 1, runs all semester). A lightweight journaling module where you log connections, surprises, and reform-relevant observations as you read. It is one convenient place to keep the reading journal that counts toward participation. The ten entries are what count, not the module. It will not write your paper. It will help you not arrive at Week 10 with a blank page.

8/31 – Week 2: Why Are So Many Americans Poor?

Readings

- Howard, chapter 2: “Tracks of My Tiers”
- Desmond, chapters 1–2: “The Kind of Problem Poverty Is” & “Why Haven’t We Made More Progress?”

In-class activity

- **Baseline writing diagnostic** (Monday August 31, in-class, ~20 min, unaided). Short response to a course prompt; not graded for content, counts toward participation. See AI policy for purpose.

9/7 – Week 3: American Exceptionalism?

Monday September 7 is Labor Day — no class. Wednesday September 9 only.

Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 1: “She So Unusual”
- Desmond, chapters 3–4: “How We Undercut Workers” & “How We Force the Poor to Pay More”

Grad Extension Readings

- Esping-Andersen, Gøsta. 1990. *The Three Worlds of Welfare Capitalism*, chapter 1: “The Three Political Economies of the Welfare State,” pp. 9–34 (posted on Canvas)
- Hacker, Jacob S. 2004. “Privatizing Risk without Privatizing the Welfare State.” *APSR* 98(2): 243–260

9/14 – Week 4: ASYNC — Political Development of the Welfare State

No in-person meetings. Complete readings and film by Friday, September 18. Discussion Paper 1 due Friday 11:59 p.m.

Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 3: “Twice in a Lifetime”
- Pierson, Paul. 1993. “When Effect Becomes Cause: Policy Feedback and Political Change.” *World Politics* 45(4): 595–628 (posted on Canvas)

Grad Extension Readings

- Baumgartner, Frank and Bryan Jones. 2009. *Agendas and Instability in American Politics*, 2nd ed., chapters 1–3. *Ask me for a copy—I keep one in my office and will lend it for the semester.*

Film

- *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 2 (PBS Frontline, 2021, 54 min.)

Assignments

- **Discussion Paper 1 due Friday September 18, 11:59 p.m.:** both parts of *Growing Up Poor in America* with Howard chapter 3 and Pierson

PART II: Programs of the Welfare State

9/21 – Week 5: Social Security and Medicare

Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 4: “Ogres, Onions, and Layers (or, How Republicans Built the American Welfare State)”
- Berkowitz, Edward D. and Larry DeWitt. “Social Security,” chapter 15 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)
- Oberlander, Jonathan. “Medicare,” chapter 17 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

Recommended Readings

- Greszler, Rachel. 2021. “Seven Hard Truths Americans Should Know About Social Security in 2021—and Five Ways to Strengthen Social Security.” Heritage Foundation Issue Brief 5212, September 3, 2021

- Center on Budget and Policy Priorities. “Policy Basics: Top Ten Facts about Social Security.” Updated May 31, 2024. <https://www.cbpp.org/research/social-security/top-ten-facts-about-social-security> (PDF snapshot on Canvas—CBPP revises this page, so use the Canvas copy so we are all reading the same numbers.)

These two are a matched pair, arguing opposite sides of the same program. Read together they are the best preparation in the course for the Source and Claims Memo, where the question is where a number came from and who is served by stating it that way.

Assignments

- Policy brief topic selection due Monday September 21 (brief Canvas post)

PapyrusAI module

- **Policy Brief Scaffold** unlocks after topic selection. Per-program modules (OASDI, SSI, TANF, UI, Medicaid, Medicare, SNAP, EITC) walk you through stated purpose, beneficiaries, design features, and reform debate. Module asks questions; you write the brief.

9/28 – Week 6: The Safety Net, Part 1 — TANF, SNAP, and the EITC

Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 5: “Programs for the Poor are not Always Poor Programs”
- Campbell, chapters 1–3: “Trying to Make it in America”; “Down the Rabbit Hole”; “The Place of the Poor in the American Welfare State”
- Desmond, chapter 5: “How We Rely on Welfare”

Recommended Readings

- Gitterman, Daniel. “The Politics of Supporting Low-Wage Workers and Families,” chapter 21 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)
- Gundersen, Craig. “Food Assistance Programs and Food Security,” chapter 22 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

Assignments

- **Discussion Paper 2 due Friday October 2, 11:59 p.m.**

10/5 – Week 7: The Safety Net, Part 2 — Housing, Income, and Medicaid

Readings

- Howard, chapter 8: “The American States: Laboratories of Democracy or Cryogenic Chambers?”
- Howard, *Who Cares*, chapters 5–7: “Income”; “Food”; “Housing” (Pollak)
- Grogan, Colleen M. and Christina M. Andrews. “Medicaid,” chapter 19 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

Assignments

- **Graduate Research Proposals due Monday October 5** (1–2 pages). Topic may be revised through the Week 14 outline milestone; scope feedback is the priority at this stage.
- **Policy Brief source and claims memo due Friday October 9 (undergraduates)** (5%). One page separating what you can support from a named source you have read from what you are still assuming.

PapyrusAI module

- **Research Paper Coach** (grad) unlocks after proposal submission. Argues back against your thesis, probes evidence, and pushes you to articulate counterarguments. Will not draft paragraphs.

10/12 – Week 8: Midterm Review and Midterm Exam

*Monday October 12: midterm review. Wednesday October 14: **MIDTERM EXAM** (in-class).*

PART III: Case Studies in Reform

10/19 – Week 9: ASYNC — Welfare Reform

No in-person meetings. Complete readings and film by Friday, October 23. Discussion Paper 3 due Friday 11:59 p.m.

Core Readings

- Campbell, chapters 4–5
- Béland, Daniel and Alex Waddan. 2012. “Welfare Reform, 1996,” chapter 1 in *The Politics of Policy Change*
- Rank et al., *Poorly Understood*, Section IV: “Does Welfare Work?” pp. 116–145 (Pollak)

Recommended Readings

- Semuels, Alana. 2016. “The End of Welfare as We Know It.” *The Atlantic*
- Rector, Robert, Jamie Bryan Hall, and Leslie Ford. 2022. “A Road Map for Conservative, Pro-Family Welfare Reform.” Heritage Foundation Issue Brief 5298, December 9, 2022

Grad Extension Readings

- Soss, Joe and Sanford F. Schram. 2007. “A Public Transformed? Welfare Reform as Policy Feedback.” *APSR* 101(1): 111–127

Film

- *Two American Families* (PBS Frontline, 2013, 60 min.)
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/two-american-families/>

Assignments

- **Discussion Paper 3 due Friday October 23, 11:59 p.m.:** *Two American Families* with the welfare reform readings

10/26 – Week 10: Health Care Reform and the ACA

Readings

- Jacobs, Lawrence and Theda Skocpol. *Health Care Reform and American Politics*, chapters 1–4 (Pollak)
- Hacker, Jacob. 2010. “The Road to Somewhere: Why Health Reform Happened.” *Perspectives on Politics* 8(3): 861–876

Assignments

- **Policy Briefs due Wednesday October 28 (undergraduates)**

PapyrusAI module

- **Term Paper Dialectical Partner** (undergrad) unlocks after the brief is submitted. Argues back against your thesis, asks for evidence on each claim, and challenges counterarguments. Will not draft paragraphs.

11/2 – Week 11: Documentary Screening and Synthesis Discussion

This week steps back from the reading cycle for structured documentary discussion and synthesis across Parts I–III. Review your notes before class.

Film (in-class or assigned in advance)

- *Poverty, Politics and Profit* (PBS Frontline, 2017, 54 min.)
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/poverty-politics-and-profit/>

Assignments

- **Discussion Paper 4 due Friday November 6, 11:59 p.m.:** *Poverty, Politics and Profit* with the welfare reform and ACA units

PART IV: Political Forces Shaping the Welfare State

11/9 – Week 12: Race and the Welfare State, Part 1

Monday November 9 only — November 11 is Veterans Day; no class.

Readings

- Howard, chapter 9: “Race Still Matters”
- Gilens, Martin. 1999. *Why Americans Hate Welfare*, chapter 3: “Racial Attitudes, the Undeserving Poor, and Opposition to Welfare” (posted on Canvas). Skim chapter 5, “The News Media and the Racialization of Poverty,” also posted.

11/16 – Week 13: Race Part 2 and Gender and the Welfare State

Core Readings

- Michener, Jamila. 2020. “Race, Politics, and the Affordable Care Act.” *Journal of Health Politics, Policy and Law* 45(4): 547–566
- Mettler, Suzanne. 1998. *Dividing Citizens: Gender and Federalism in New Deal Public Policy*, chapters 1, 5–6 (Pollak, JSTOR)

Recommended Readings

- Morgan, Kimberly J. 2013. “Policies for Work/Life Balance in the United States.” *Informations Sociales* 177: 140–149 (in French as “Quelles politiques publiques pour concilier vie familiale et vie professionnelle?”; <https://doi.org/10.3917/inso.177.0140>)
- Gornick, Janet C. and Natascia Boeri. “Gender and Poverty,” chapter 10 in *The Oxford Handbook of the Social Science of Poverty* (Brady and Burton, eds., 2016)

Assignments

- Discussion Paper 5 due Friday November 20, 11:59 p.m.

Thanksgiving Break: November 23–27. No class.

11/30 – Week 14: ASYNC — Public Opinion and Interest Groups

No in-person meetings, and no discussion paper this week—reading and independent work time. Term papers and graduate outlines are due Wednesday, December 2.

Readings

- Howard, chapter 6: “Shaq is Still Pretty Tall: Public Support for the American Welfare State”
- Howard, chapter 7: “The World According to AARP”
- Desmond, chapter 6: “How We Buy Opportunity”
- Howard, *Who Cares*: “Business and Labor” (Pollak)

Assignments

- **Term Papers due Wednesday December 2 (undergraduates)**
- **Graduate Introductions, Outlines, and Annotated Bibliographies due Wednesday December 2**

12/7 – Week 15: Solutions and Course Synthesis

Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 10: “Change versus Progress”
- Campbell, chapter 6: “Conclusion: The Future of American Means-Tested Programs”
- Desmond, chapters 7–8

Recommended Readings

- Desmond, chapter 9: “Tear Down the Walls,” and the Epilogue
- Piven, Frances Fox and Lorraine C. Minnite. “Poor People’s Politics,” chapter 33 in *The Oxford Handbook of the Social Science of Poverty* (Brady and Burton, eds., 2016)

Assignments

- Wednesday December 9: Final exam review

12/14 – Week 16: Finals Week

Deliverables

- **Final Exam: Monday, December 14, 1:00–2:50 p.m.**, GH 305
- **Graduate Final Research Papers due:** Monday, December 14, at the start of the final exam